

scenario and budget. There are several types of headphones (in-ears are also headphones) and each one brings with it a set of advantages and drawbacks.

Understanding types

In-ear: In ear headphones, or IEMs (in-ear monitors) as they're popularly called, are the type of headphones that are inserted in the ear canal. IEMs are responsible for making the esoteric world of audiophilia accessible to normal people. Because the driver is so close to the eardrum and they manage a good seal, IEMs by and large sound quite good. They're cheaper compared to proper full-sized headphones that deliver a similar audio experience. In-ears are small, easy to carry and preferable for use during daily commutes. Today, there are many specialised variants available even in the IEM space.



In-ear headphones or IEMs

You have rugged headphones that are meant for wearing while running or gymming. These tend to be water resistant or sweat proof. Many come with flanges or specially shaped tips that latch on to the grooves of your cochlea for stability (like the ones pictured). You also get active noise cancelling ones.

Supra-aural: These headphones are the kind that rest on top of your ear. They're usually designed with portability in mind so they may have folding mechanisms on two axes. Most people don't find supra-aural headphones very comfortable but many others don't have any complaints with the form factor at all. So it's all a very subjective thing. Borrow a pair from your friends and try it on for an



Supra-aural headphones: They fold and sit on your ear. May or may not be your thing depending on your comfort expectations

hour or two to really get a feel for whether this format works for you. Important things to consider while assessing supra-aural headphones are clamping pressure, pad material and build quality. Clamping pressure and the materials used for the ear-pads go a long way into making them comfortable. If they press too hard on your ears you'll feel uncomfortable after a while. At the same time, they can't be so loose that a minor shove will dislodge them from your head. Good quality ear pads these days are made of materials that don't get too warm and sweaty. Supra-aural headphones are sometimes called "on-ear" and "over-the-ear" too, and there are minor design variants dubbed "supra-cochlea" and "intra-cochlea" or some other hard-to-remember terms, but you don't really need to bother with those. If they don't completely encircle your ear, they're supra-aural.

Circumaural: These are headphones that go completely around the ear i.e. headphones that encompass the ear. By far, these are the most comfortable of the lot. This is also the form factor of choice for extremely high fidelity units to come in. Circumaural headphones are big, not necessarily heavy, but they just occupy a lot of space. Ideally, they're meant to be listened to at home, preferably through an amp if you happen to have one. If you want good audio at a fixed place with the utmost comfort you should consider this category.

Open, closed back, semi-open: These are not really types, but more like construction styles for all three aforemen-

tioned types of headphones. The construction style refers to the kind of housing the drivers are enclosed in. So, for example, if the back side of the ear cups is completely closed, they're "closed back". This means that outside or ambient noise is kept to a minimum while at the same time sound from the headphones doesn't leak outside. The choice of enclosure affects the sound quality quite a bit. "Open back" headphones feel well open and airy and the audio feels more expansive. This is often referred to as the soundstage being wider. There are open back IEMs too these days, especially in the fitness sub-segment. The



Max comfort and max heft. An example of a circumaural headphone